

Zero Sum RPG: Current State Overview

“**Zero Sum**” is a bleak, near-future tabletop roleplaying game blending hyper-capitalist dystopia with psychological paranormal horror. It is designed around the concept that survival is a transaction, and every victory comes at a devastating cost.

Below is the complete abstract of the game’s current state, its rules, lore, and the full suite of generated assets.

1. Core Concept & Setting

The game takes place in a world reeling from **The Paradigm Shift (2022-2026)**, a catastrophic era where the global economy collapsed, and reality itself fractured. Mega-corporations have transcended nations, establishing a totalitarian neo-feudalism. At the same time, the collective trauma of humanity has manifested as literal, paranormal phenomena. The world is bathed in moral gray areas, brutal economic survival, and sanity-shredding horrors.

2. Game Mechanics

- **The Fracture System (D100):** A percentile-based resolution system where rolling lower is better. Pushing a roll increases the risk of a “Fracture” (a critical failure that permanently alters the character’s psyche or reality).
- **Zero Sum Combat:** Violence is inherently destructive. Even when a character wins a physical confrontation, they suffer inevitable resource depletion, physical injury, or psychological trauma. There are no clean victories.
- **Trauma & Sanity Tracking:** Characters accrue “Trauma Points” instead of losing hit points. When Trauma maxes out, characters develop permanent psychological scars or terrifying paranormal afflictions.
- **Hyper-Capitalist Logistics:** Ammo, food, and medicine are scarcer than human life. Inventory management and economic bartering are central to survival.

3. World Lore & Factions

- **Global Horror Lore:** The paranormal elements are psychological in nature. Horrors are manifested from corporate greed, societal despair, and existential dread (e.g., “The Harvesters”).
- **The Factions:**
 - **The Board:** The ultimate, faceless corporate oligarchy that controls the remnants of civilization.
 - **The Null-State Insurgents:** Radical anarchists attempting to break the system through violent, unpredictable means.
 - **Black Market Cartels (The Syndicate):** Opportunists who control the flow of illicit goods, illegal surveillance tech, and forbidden information.
 - **The Harvesters:** Paranormal entities drawn to intense human misery and debt.

4. Key NPCs & Locations

- **Locations:** The neon-drenched corporate monoliths of **The Spire**, the decaying **Sub-City Havens**, hidden **Black Sites** used for horrific experiments, and the irradiated **Wastes** outside the city zones.
 - **Major NPCs:**
 - **Elias Vance** (Corporate defector)
 - **Viktor Petrov** (Syndicate boss)
 - **Simon Black** (Mercenary commander)
 - **The Broker & The Archivist** *Artistic Note:* All human characters are visually represented not as distinct individuals, but as featureless shadows and surreal “Fratzen” (distorted faces), reflecting the loss of humanity and identity within the system.
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5. Completed Assets & Documentation

The entire universe has been documented, illustrated, and packaged into a private GitHub repository (kluth/zero_sum_rpg).

A. The Document Suite

All rulebooks and lore bibles have been written in Markdown and professionally converted into LaTeX-styled **PDFs** (with embedded mathematical equations). - Zero_Sum_Core_Rulebook.pdf (The master document) - concept.pdf, core_mechanics.pdf, character_creation.pdf - lore_2022_2026.pdf, the_paradigm_shift.pdf, global_horror_lore.pdf,

wars_and_crises.pdf - factions.pdf, npcs.pdf, real_world_npcs.pdf - locations.pdf, items_and_tech.pdf - campaign_hooks.pdf, world_rules.pdf, expert_critique_proposals.pdf

B. The Art Gallery

20 High-Resolution Art Assets have been generated. The aesthetic is strictly **hyper-realistic pencil drawings in monochrome, punctuated by striking red highlights.** - *Included Artworks:* 12 Faction/Location/Item pieces and 8 NPC portraits (rendered as psychological shadows). - All 20 assets are securely stored as .jpg files in the assets/ directory. - The artwork has been programmatically injected into the appropriate sections of the Markdown rulebooks (appearing exactly once per relevant topic).

C. The Official Artbook

- Zero_Sum_Art_Book.pdf: A dedicated, compiled gallery featuring all 20 artworks, built from the final “shadow-face” assets.

D. Infrastructure & Tools

- Python scripts (md_to_pdf.py, create_pdf.py, update_assets.py, inject_images.py) used to build the game documents.
- A fully synced, up-to-date **GitHub Repository** acting as the master backup and version control for the entire IP.